AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 3

The Benefits, Licensing and Casework Playbook

Behind the front door: eligibility explained, evidence handled once, licences decided fairly - with AI that prepares, checks and summarises, and officers who decide.



Gates B0-B5 | 8 Templates | 20 Golden Rules

The worked example continues: **Northbridge City and County**, a fictional composite government of 480,000 residents administering housing benefit, disability support, business licensing and family casework - 214,000 live cases, 38,000 new applications a month. Every figure attached to Northbridge is illustrative. Adapt thresholds to your own statute, budget and risk appetite.

Executive / Service / Accountability lenses on every major section, so a cabinet member, a caseworker and an auditor can read the same page and each find their decision.

START HERE

Casework is where the state keeps or breaks its promises

Volume 2 built the front door. This volume owns what happens after a resident walks through it: the application assembled, the evidence checked, the licence assessed, the case carried - sometimes for years - by a named worker who knows the family, the business, the history.

How to use this playbook

- **Casework and licensing leads** read pages 4-16 and run every use case against the gates on page 29.
- **Executives** read pages 6, 23-25 and 29, and hold the stop list on page 7 personally.
- **Caseworkers and assessors** read pages 13-22 first; their desk is designed there, not in the vendor demo.
- **Auditors and oversight** start at pages 23, 27 and 29-32: measurement, failure drills, gates, templates and rules.

The one test that matters

Every design choice answers one question: **does this help a qualified officer make a right, explainable decision, faster - without shifting burden onto the applicant?** Speed bought by pushing work, doubt or error onto residents is not speed; it is cost transfer with better branding.

AI prepares. Officers decide. **The decision, the reason and the appeal route are always human-owned.**

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the accuracy rate and the appeal-upheld rate; they matter more than the processing time.

SERVICE LENS

A case is progressed when the applicant knows what was decided, why, and what happens next.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every automated check leaves a trace an auditor - and the applicant - can follow to the source.

THE SERIES

Where this volume sits

Vol	Title	Owns
1	Strategy	Mandate, portfolio, risk tiers, gates S0-S5
2	Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors	Find, understand, apply, track, contact
3	Benefits, Licensing and Casework	Eligibility support, evidence, caseworker tools (this volume)
4	Permitting, Planning and Land Use	Applications, completeness, inspections
5	Tax, Revenue and Compliance	Filing support, queries, payment, debt
6	Procurement and Supplier AI	Buying, contracts, model and supplier governance
7	Emergency Services and Public Safety	Dispatch support, triage, public alerts
8	Data, Records and Interoperability	Registers, records, sharing, retention
9	Workforce, Ethics and Public Trust	Roles, skills, ethics review, public reporting
10	Government Capstone and Assurance	Whole-portfolio assurance and the licence to scale

Contents of this volume

Casework today: the queue is a symptom	4
The case lifecycle, end to end	5
Where AI pays in casework	6
The stop list: decisions AI never makes	7
Ten design principles	8
Eligibility, explained before it is assessed	9
Rules as code, law as source	10
Evidence: asked once, checked kindly	11
Document intelligence with a human check	12
The case summary: one page, whole story	13
Drafting decisions and letters officers sign	14
Triage and allocation without hidden bias	15
Licensing: proportionate, predictable, appealable	16
Renewals, changes and the case that never closes	17
Complex and vulnerable cases	18
Safeguarding signals, human response	19
Fraud, error and the presumption of honesty	20
Appeals, reconsideration and learning loops	21
The caseworker desk and the working day	22
Trust, records and the public register	23
Measurement: right first time, fair by group	24
Economics of casework	25
Workforce: judgement is the job	26
When casework AI fails	27
Build, buy and supplier discipline	28
Gates B0-B5 and the 24-month roadmap	29
Templates 1-4	30
Templates 5-8 and the assurance checklist	31
20 Golden Rules	32

DIAGNOSIS

The queue is a symptom, not the disease

Northbridge audited 2,000 closed cases before automating anything. A third of elapsed time was waiting for evidence the county already held in another system. One in five applications was touched eleven times or more. Letters went out that applicants could not act on, generating calls, generating more letters. The backlog was real; its causes were mostly self-inflicted.

What the audit counts

- **Touches:** how many times a case is opened without progress. Every touch without a decision, a request or an update is waste with a timestamp.
- **Waits:** where cases sit, for how long, and waiting for whom - applicant, another agency, or an internal queue nobody owns.
- **Rework:** evidence re-requested, forms re-sent, assessments redone because the first record could not be trusted or found.
- **Failure demand:** contacts caused by unclear letters, missed deadlines and unexplained refusals - demand the service created itself.

> **Northbridge baseline (illustrative):** median benefit decision 34 days against a 21-day standard; 27 percent of licence applications incomplete on arrival; 18 percent of refused applications overturned on reconsideration - the clearest sign the first decision process, not the applicants, needed fixing.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the audit before the model. Automating this workflow would decide wrong cases faster.

SERVICE LENS

Attack waits and rework first; they are larger than any model's time saving.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An overturn rate that high is a quality alarm. Publish it and treat it as one.

THE WORK

One case, one lifecycle, no black holes

Benefits, licences and family cases differ in law but share a skeleton. Name the stages, give each an owner and a clock, and let the applicant see the same map the officer sees.

Stage	What happens	AI may	Officer owns
Intake	Application received, registered, acknowledged	Extract data, check completeness, acknowledge instantly	Confirming the case exists and the clock has started
Evidence	Supporting facts gathered and verified	Match, classify, flag gaps with plain explanations	Deciding what is sufficient and asking for more
Assessment	Facts tested against the rules	Assemble the rule trace and a draft assessment	The judgement, including discretion where law allows it
Decision	Outcome issued with reasons	Draft the decision letter from the signed assessment	Signing, issuing and standing behind the decision
Payment / grant	Entitlement paid or licence issued	Reconcile amounts, schedule, detect duplicates	Authorising payment or grant
Review	Changes, renewals, periodic checks	Pre-fill from held data, flag material change	Deciding continued entitlement
Closure / appeal	Case closed, or challenged and re-examined	Summarise grounds, route to a fresh officer	The reconsideration and the learning it triggers

The lifecycle rule: a case is never in a state with no owner, no next action and no date. Dashboards that count cases but cannot say who is waiting for what are decoration.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Manage the lifecycle, not the inbox. Queues hide; stages with clocks do not.

SERVICE LENS

Show applicants the stage map. Most anxiety is not the wait, it is not knowing.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every stage transition is recorded: who, when, on what evidence. That record is the appeal file.

THE OPPORTUNITY

AI pays in preparation, checking and summarising

Casework time splits into reading, matching, chasing, drafting and deciding. The first four are volume work where AI earns its keep. Deciding is the officer's statutory act (page 7).

Use	What it does	Pay-off
Intake extraction	Reads forms and uploads into structured case data	No re-keying; faster registration; fewer transcription errors
Completeness check	Tests an application against the published evidence list	Applicants fix gaps once, early, in plain language
Evidence matching	Matches documents to requirements and to data already held	Less re-requesting; shorter waits
Case summary	Builds a one-page chronology from the record, cited to source	Officers start from understanding, not archaeology
Rule trace	Shows which rules the facts engage and where discretion sits	Consistent assessments; reasons written as you go
Drafting	Drafts letters, decisions and notes from the signed assessment	Officer time moves to judgement and contact
Change detection	Flags life changes that may affect entitlement, for review	Reviews start from signals, not blanket re-application
Workload signals	Forecasts volumes and ageing by stage and team	Managers staff the queue before it becomes a crisis

Start where officers **drown in paper**, not where they exercise judgement. The savings are real and the risk is containable.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence by officer pain and error cost: extraction, evidence and summaries before anything clever.

SERVICE LENS

Every use above prepares or drafts; a person or a deterministic rule still commits the outcome.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If the summary cannot cite its sources in the record, it does not go on the case.

THE BOUNDARY

The stop list: decisions AI never makes

These lines hold regardless of model quality, backlog pressure or vendor claims. They are Volume 1's risk tiers applied at the point of determination.

Never automated	Why	What AI may do instead
Granting, refusing or reducing a benefit	Statutory judgement affecting a right and an income	Prepare the assessment and the rule trace for an officer
Granting or refusing a licence	Affects a livelihood; conditions need proportionality	Check completeness; draft conditions for an assessor
Safeguarding determinations	Duty of care and context a model cannot hold	Surface signals to a trained human the same day (p19)
Fraud findings or suspicion scores used as fact	Suspicion is not evidence; labels follow people	Route anomalies for human verification; record outcomes either way
Sanctions, penalties and overpayment recovery decisions	Coercive state action; hardship must be weighed	Calculate options; an officer decides with hardship in view
Closing a case for non-response alone	Silence has many causes - illness, literacy, fear, a lost letter	Prompt across channels; a person reviews before closure
Appeal outcomes	The challenger deserves a fresh human judgement	Summarise grounds and route to an officer not previously involved

> **The signature rule:** every decision letter names the deciding officer and the evidence relied on. If no human can sign it, it does not go out.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sign the stop list personally. It will be tested by a backlog, a budget round and a vendor, in that order.

SERVICE LENS

Teach the stop list to every assessor; they hold it at the end of a long day, not the steering group.

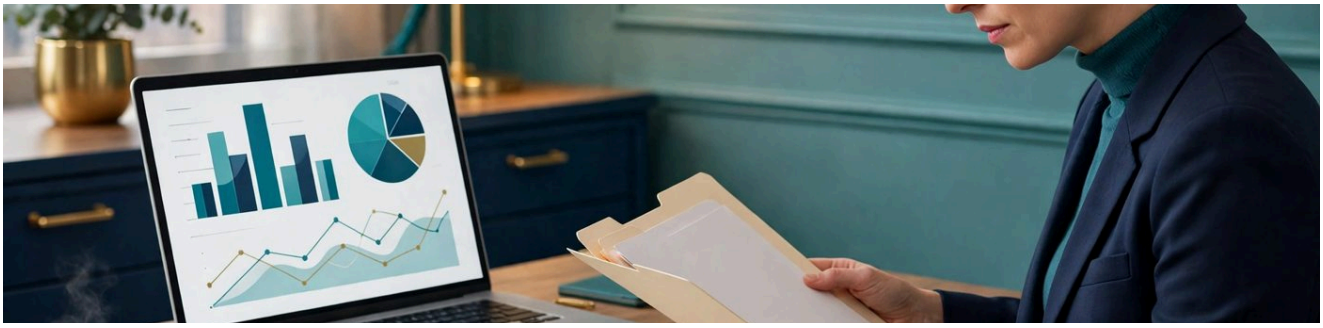
ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log every attempted breach in testing and production; the log is assurance evidence.

DESIGN

Ten principles, tested at every gate

1. **AI prepares, officers decide.** No outcome without a named human decision-maker.
2. **Right first time beats fast.** A quick wrong refusal costs the applicant, the appeal system and trust.
3. **Ask once.** Evidence the state already holds is never re-requested from the resident.
4. **Reasons are part of the decision.** Written at decision time, in plain language, from the rule trace.
5. **The presumption of honesty.** Most error is error. Verification is proportionate and explained.
6. **Discretion is visible.** Where law allows judgement, the system shows the space - it does not quietly close it.
7. **Equity is measured, not asserted.** Outcomes by group, language and channel, reviewed on a cadence (p24).
8. **The record is the case.** Summaries cite sources; drafts are labelled; nothing enters the record invisibly.
9. **Vulnerability changes the route, not the standard.** More support, more time, a named worker - same rights.
10. **Appeals are data.** Every overturn teaches the first decision process something specific.



The caseworker's desk: a cited summary, the evidence and the rule trace - preparation done, judgement still to come.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Refuse tools that breach a principle and promise configuration later; later is where principles go to die.

SERVICE LENS

Test each principle on a named case type at every gate; principles without tests are posters.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A principle breach in production is an incident, with an owner and a clock.

ELIGIBILITY

Explained before it is assessed

Most refused applications were never eligible; most eligible residents never apply. Both failures start in the same place: criteria written as statute, published as PDFs, and understood by neither group. Eligibility work begins before the form.

The eligibility discipline

- **Plain-language criteria first.** Every benefit and licence publishes who it is for, what it pays or permits, what evidence proves it, and what excludes - tested with residents, in every published language.
- **A checker that helps, not decides.** An AI-guided eligibility checker asks only the questions the rules need, explains why each is asked, and ends with "likely", "unlikely" or "unclear - talk to us", never a determination. Its answers create no record used against the applicant.
- **Near-miss routing.** "Unlikely for this, likely for that": the checker routes to adjacent support - the refusal that helps is the one that points somewhere.
- **Worked examples.** Three anonymised examples per scheme - granted, refused, borderline - teach more than forty pages of guidance.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** after the checker and plain criteria launched, ineligible applications fell by a third, and applications from eligible non-claimants in two target wards rose measurably - the same intervention cutting waste and closing a take-up gap.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Take-up is a performance measure, not a communications outcome; own it in the service line.

SERVICE LENS

The checker is a service with an owner, tested against real cases monthly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A checker result is advice, clearly labelled; it must never surface inside an assessment as evidence.

RULES

Rules as code, law as source

Eligibility logic lives in statute, regulation, guidance and habit - in that order of authority, and often in reverse order of use. Digitising casework forces the hierarchy into the open, which is uncomfortable and exactly the point.

Layer	Holds	Rule
Statute and regulation	The law itself	The only source of entitlement; cited by section in every rule trace
Deterministic rules engine	Calculable criteria: dates, amounts, thresholds, residency	Versioned, tested against worked examples, change-controlled like law
Published guidance	How officers interpret and apply discretion	Public, dated, owned; the AI reads only this version
Model assistance	Summaries, extraction, drafting, explanation	Never a source of rules; if the model and the engine disagree, the engine and the officer win
Local practice	Team habits and workarounds	Audited against guidance quarterly; unwritten rules are defects

Change discipline: when law or guidance changes, the rules engine, the checker, the guidance the model reads and the training material change together, from one change record, before the effective date - or the service declares which version decided each case in the gap.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund a rules owner per scheme. Shared ownership of rules means no ownership of errors.

SERVICE LENS

Every rule in the engine names its legal source; a rule that cannot is removed until it can.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep the full version history. Appeals are decided against the rules in force at the time.

EVIDENCE

Asked once, checked kindly

Evidence is where applicants feel the state's trust, or its absence. The design goal is simple: the minimum evidence the law requires, obtained the easiest way for the applicant, verified once, and reused everywhere the law allows.

The evidence standard

- **Check held data first.** Before asking, search the registers the applicant has already consented to share - income, residency, existing awards, licensed status. The request list is what remains, and it is usually short.
- **Explain every item.** Each request says what is needed, why, what formats count, and what to do if you do not have it. "Proof of circumstances" is not an evidence request; it is a riddle.
- **Alternatives of equal standing.** A bank statement, a letter, a staffed verification at a service centre - where law allows alternatives, all are offered, none is treated as suspicious.
- **One gap letter, once.** AI assembles a single, complete list of what is missing, in plain language, with a realistic deadline and a named contact. Drip-feed requests are a design failure, not applicant failure.
- **Receipts for everything.** Every upload and document is acknowledged with what was received and what it satisfied. "Did you get it?" should be unaskable.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Measure evidence burden per scheme: items requested, days spent gathering, repeats. Publish it.

SERVICE LENS

The kindest check is the one the applicant never sees because held data already answered it.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A deadline that ignores how long evidence takes to obtain manufactures refusals.

EVIDENCE

Document intelligence with a human check

Reading documents at scale is AI's clearest casework win - and its easiest place to quietly do harm, because a misread date or amount enters the record looking like fact.

Step	What the system does	Safeguard
Classify	Identifies document type and the requirement it addresses	Low-confidence documents go to a human queue, never auto-filed
Extract	Pulls dates, amounts, names and reference numbers	Every extracted field shows its source image region on demand
Validate	Checks dates in range, amounts consistent, document in date	Conflicts are flagged as questions, not resolved silently
Match	Links the document to the case and the evidence item	Applicant gets the receipt and can correct a mismatch
File	Stores the document and extraction in the record	Original always retained; extraction is a layer, never a replacement

Accuracy discipline

- **Sampled human verification** on every document class, with accuracy published by class - handwriting, low-quality scans and non-standard formats get higher sampling, not lower standards.
- **Confidence is shown, not hidden.** Officers see which fields were uncertain; the interface makes checking the doubtful field the easiest action on the screen.
- **Errors correct forward.** A corrected extraction updates the record, flags any assessment that used the wrong value, and the correction is visible to the applicant.



Licensing done proportionately: the applicant guided once, the evidence checked once, the decision explained once.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Accuracy by document class is a gate metric; a blended average hides exactly the cases that hurt people.

SERVICE LENS

Buy extraction against tested accuracy on your documents, not the vendor's demo set.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The original document outranks its extraction in any dispute, always.

THE DESK

The case summary: one page, whole story

A caseworker opening a two-year case faces 300 documents and forty minutes of archaeology before the first useful thought. The AI case summary ends that: one page, chronologically honest, cited to the record, refreshed at every material event.

What a trustworthy summary contains

- **The story:** who this case is about, what they applied for, what has been decided, what is outstanding - in the order it happened.
- **The evidence state:** what is held, verified, missing or in dispute, each item linked to its source document.
- **The flags:** vulnerability, safeguarding history, language needs, representatives, previous appeals - surfaced, never buried, never scored.
- **The open questions:** what the officer still needs to decide, ask or verify, stated as questions.

> **The citation rule:** every sentence of fact in the summary traces to a record entry the officer can open in one click. A summary that cannot show its sources is a rumour with good formatting - and officers learn to ignore summaries they cannot trust, which wastes the entire investment.

What the summary never does

- It never recommends an outcome. It may list the rules engaged (page 10); the assessment is the officer's.
- It never omits inconvenient facts. Selection is tested: assurance samples summaries against full records specifically hunting for omissions.
- It never becomes the record. The underlying documents remain the truth; the summary is a view, labelled with its generation time.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Summary quality is a safety property; sample it like one, especially omissions.

SERVICE LENS

Officers correct summaries; corrections are training data for the process, not blame for the officer.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If officers keep printing the whole file, the summary has failed - ask why, and fix the summary.

THE DESK

Drafting decisions and letters officers sign

Decision letters are where accuracy, law and empathy meet - or collide. AI drafting from the signed assessment, the rule trace and the evidence state produces consistent, complete letters. The officer edits, owns and signs.

Element	Drafted from	Checked by the officer
Outcome	The signed assessment	That it matches the decision actually taken
Reasons	The rule trace, in plain language	That each reason is true, sufficient and the real reason
Evidence relied on	The evidence state	That nothing material is missing or misdescribed
Numbers	The rules engine calculation	Spot check on sampled cases; full check where amounts are large
Next steps	Appeal rights, deadlines, contacts	That routes and dates are correct for this scheme and date
Tone	Plain-language standard	That it reads as a person explaining, not a system notifying

Drafting discipline

- **Draft after decision, never before.** The workflow order is assessment, decision, draft. A draft that exists before the decision invites the decision to copy it.
- **Edits are data.** Where officers consistently rewrite a phrase, the template is wrong; review edit patterns monthly and fix templates, not officers.
- **No unsent drafts in the record as decisions.** Drafts are labelled, versioned and clearly not the issued letter.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Letter quality shows up in appeal volumes and call queues within weeks; watch both after any template change.

SERVICE LENS

Consistency is a fairness property: like cases should read alike, because they were decided alike.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The sign-off is real only if officers have time to read. Staffing that assumes zero reading time produces rubber stamps.

ALLOCATION

Triage and allocation without hidden bias

Someone must decide which case goes to whom, in what order. AI can forecast, group and route - and can just as easily encode yesterday's inequities as tomorrow's queue order.

The allocation standard

- **Route on need and skill, not on worth.** Complexity, vulnerability, language and deadline drive allocation. Predicted "likelihood of refusal" never does.
- **Clocks before queues.** Statutory deadlines and hardship signals sort the queue before arrival order; every reprioritisation is logged with its reason.
- **Workload is visible.** Caseload by worker, case age by team and ageing hotspots are published internally weekly; invisible overload becomes error.
- **Test the routing.** Quarterly, assurance checks allocation and outcome patterns by protected characteristic, language and channel. A disparity is investigated as a defect, not explained away as demand.
- **Humans can override.** Team leaders reallocate with a recorded reason; override patterns are reviewed because they reveal where the model misunderstands the work.

Any variable that would embarrass you **read aloud in an appeal hearing** does not belong in the allocation logic.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Ask what the router optimises. If the honest answer is throughput alone, the fairness work has not been done.

SERVICE LENS

Allocation is a public-trust surface even though the public never sees it; its effects are what they see.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Cap caseloads by complexity weight, not case count; thirty simple cases and thirty complex ones are different jobs.

LICENSING

Proportionate, predictable, appealable

Licensing is casework with a business on the other side: food premises, taxis, care providers, market traders. The principles hold, the tempo differs - a delayed licence is often a business that cannot open.

Licence type	Proportionate approach	AI support
Low-risk renewals	Light touch where compliance history is clean	Pre-filled renewal, held-data checks, fast human sign-off
New standard applications	Full assessment, published timescales	Completeness check, evidence matching, inspection scheduling
High-risk / safeguarding-adjacent	Enhanced checks, site visit, conditions	Record assembly, history summary, condition drafting for the assessor
Variations and transfers	Test only what changed	Change detection against the licensed record
Enforcement-linked	Separation between licensing and enforcement roles	No shared suspicion flags; each process keeps its own evidence standard

Licensing discipline

- **Publish the clock.** Every licence type carries a stated decision time, reported against monthly. Silence is the most common complaint and the cheapest to fix: a status that updates itself.
- **Conditions are written to be complied with.** Each condition is specific, measurable and explained; a condition the holder cannot understand will not be met and cannot fairly be enforced.
- **Refusal teaches.** A refused applicant gets the gaps in terms they can act on, and a route to reapply. Repeat applications with the same gaps are a guidance failure.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Licensing delay is economic policy whether you intend it or not; report the times like it matters.

SERVICE LENS

Risk-proportionate routes must be earned by data, reviewed yearly, and reversible on evidence.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep licensing and enforcement evidence separate; mixing them poisons both.

CONTINUITY

Renewals, changes and the case that never closes

Most casework is not new applications; it is life continuing - a child born, a job lost, a landlord selling, a licence holder expanding. Systems designed only for intake make residents re-prove an entire life to report one change.

The continuity standard

- **Report a change, not a new case.** The change journey asks what changed, from when, and what proves that - nothing else. AI assembles the delta against the existing record and shows the officer exactly what is new.
- **Pre-filled renewals.** Renewal starts from everything held, asks the resident to confirm or correct, and tests only what is time-expired or changed. A blank renewal form is an admission the data is not trusted - fix the data, not the resident.
- **Signal-led reviews.** Where law allows data matching, changes in held data raise review signals. Each signal is a question for a human, handled with notice and a chance to respond before any adjustment (page 20).
- **No silent stops.** A payment or licence never lapses because an internal review is unfinished. Continuity rules protect the resident while the state catches up, wherever statute allows.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** pre-filled renewals cut average resident effort from 90 minutes to 15, and officer handling by a third, while correction rates rose - residents fixing held data is the cheapest data-quality programme government runs.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Effort saved for residents counts in the business case alongside officer time; measure both.

SERVICE LENS

Corrections from residents are gold: route them to the register owners, not just the case.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Continuity protection is a design decision with a legal check, made explicitly per scheme.

COMPLEX CASES

The hardest cases get the most human service

Complexity is not an edge case in casework; it is the centre of the work. Multiple needs, no fixed address, trauma, addiction, language barriers, a representative, three agencies involved - these cases decide whether the service deserves trust.

The complex-case standard

- **A named worker and a single plan.** One accountable caseworker coordinates; AI maintains the shared chronology across agencies so the resident stops retelling - and re-living - the story.
- **Time is a resource, allocated deliberately.** Complex cases carry longer appointments, flexible evidence deadlines and proactive contact. The system flags approaching deadlines to the worker, never as automated warnings to the resident.
- **Support is recorded once, honoured everywhere.** Communication needs, safe contact methods, advocates and interpreters sit on the record and shape every letter, call and appointment automatically.
- **AI stays in the back office here.** Summaries, chronologies, drafting administration - yes. Outbound contact with a vulnerable resident is human, considered and timed, always.

Efficiency targets **never** apply per-case to complex work. Measure this cohort on stability, outcomes and trust, or the system will rush exactly the people it most owes care.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Ring-fence complex-case capacity in the staffing model; if it competes with intake volume, it loses.

SERVICE LENS

Ask the named worker what the system did to them this week; their answer is your usability research.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Vulnerability flags are support instructions, not risk scores. Audit any other use as a breach.

SAFEGUARDING

Signals surfaced fast, judgements made by people

Casework records hold safeguarding signals in plain sight: a child's absence pattern, a carer's exhaustion, coercion in a licensing visit, a sudden change in who collects a payment. AI's role is narrow and vital: notice patterns across a large record, and put them in front of a trained human the same day.

The safeguarding standard

- **Flag, never conclude.** The system raises a signal with the underlying record entries attached. It does not score a family, label a household, or write its inference into the case summary.
- **Same-day human review.** Every signal is reviewed by a designated safeguarding professional within the working day; the review outcome - action, monitor, no concern - is recorded by that professional.
- **False positives are expected and costed.** Thresholds are set with safeguarding leads, tuned on reviewed outcomes, and the burden of a false alarm is counted honestly; a system tuned to never be wrong will miss the case that mattered.
- **Access is restricted and logged.** Safeguarding signals are visible only to roles with the duty and the training; every view is logged.
- **Never a silent input elsewhere.** A signal, a review or a no-concern outcome never feeds allocation, fraud or enforcement logic (pages 15, 20).

EXECUTIVE LENS

The safeguarding lead owns thresholds and review times, not the technology team. Unambiguous, in writing.

SERVICE LENS

Measure review timeliness relentlessly; a signal reviewed next week is a process that looks like care.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Staff who raise concerns outside the system are backed publicly; the system is a net, not the conscience.

INTEGRITY

Fraud, error and the presumption of honesty

Most incorrect payments are error - the resident's, the department's, or the rules' complexity expressing itself. A small minority are deliberate fraud. A system that treats the whole caseload as suspects will spend heavily, wrongly accuse widely, and still miss organised fraud, which does not look like a confused pensioner.

Category	Typical cause	Proportionate response
Official error	Wrong calculation, stale data, misapplied rule	Fix, repay, apologise, correct the process; no recovery where law and hardship say no
Resident error	Misunderstood question, unreported change, bad advice	Correct going forward; education over penalty; recovery decided by an officer with hardship in view
Anomaly	Data mismatch, duplicate, timing artefact	Verify quietly against held data before any contact; most resolve without troubling the resident
Suspected fraud	Deliberate misrepresentation indicators	Human-led investigation under Volume 5 discipline; evidence standard, interview rights, no automated findings
Organised / identity fraud	Networks, synthetic identities, insider collusion	Specialist teams, cross-agency data under legal gateway, law enforcement routes

The integrity standard

- **Verify before you accuse.** No resident receives an allegation generated from a data match alone. A person checks the match, the data quality and innocent explanations first.
- **Measure accusation accuracy.** The share of investigations ending in no fraud and no error is published internally; a low hit rate means the targeting, not the public, is the problem.
- **Prevention beats pursuit.** Clearer questions, pre-filled data and real-time checks at application save more than recovery ever claws back - without the fear.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Hold the integrity budget to outcomes net of harm: money correctly paid matters as much as money recovered.

SERVICE LENS

Language matters in law and in trust: 'check' until there is evidence, 'fraud' only when proven.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Appeal and complaint rates on integrity cases are a targeting quality signal; review them together.

APPEALS

Reconsideration is the quality system working in public

An appeal is not an attack on the service; it is the service being told, precisely, where it may be wrong. AI helps appeals move fast and fairly - and helps the first decision process learn, which is where the lasting value sits.

The appeals standard

- **Easy to start, in any channel.** A phone call, a letter, a form, a representative - all open a reconsideration, registered the same day, with the clock and the process explained in plain language.
- **A fresh human decides.** Reconsideration goes to an officer not involved in the original decision, with an AI-assembled pack: grounds, original rule trace, evidence and any new material - assembled for review, never pre-judged.
- **Payments protected where law allows.** The applicant is told what happens to payments and licence status during review, in the acknowledgement, not discovered later.
- **Every outcome teaches.** Overturns are coded by cause - evidence missed, rule misapplied, discretion not exercised, letter unclear, new facts. The cause table is reviewed monthly by the scheme owner and drives fixes in that order.
- **Upheld decisions explain better.** A clear, respectful explanation of why the original decision stands, with the further appeal route, is a service outcome, not a defeat.

> **Northbridge (illustrative):** cause-coding showed 40 percent of overturns were "evidence held but not seen" - a record retrieval problem wearing a legal costume. Fixing evidence matching (page 11) cut overturns by a quarter in two quarters.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Never set a target to reduce appeals. Set a target to reduce the causes of overturns; appeals themselves are a right in use.

SERVICE LENS

A rising appeal rate after a change is an early-warning sensor. Thank it and investigate.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The fresh-eyes rule is absolute; workload pressure is not an exception, it is a staffing signal.

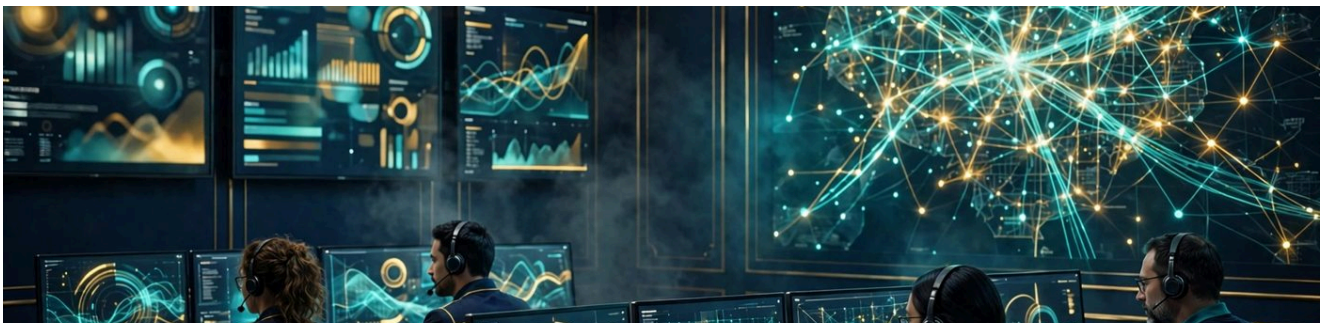
THE DESK

One screen, the whole case, time to think

Tools succeed at the desk or nowhere. The caseworker desk is designed backwards from a working day: a prioritised queue with reasons, the case opened at the summary, every action reachable without re-keying, and drafting help that appears where the officer already works.

Desk element	Design rule	Failure it prevents
My queue	Sorted by clock and hardship, with the reason for the order visible	Cases ageing invisibly in arrival order
Case summary	One page, cited, refreshed (p13)	Forty minutes of archaeology per case
Evidence panel	Held, verified, missing - with source images one click away	Re-requesting what the state already holds
Rule trace	Rules engaged, discretion points marked (p10)	Inconsistent assessments between officers
Draft pane	Letters and notes drafted from the decision (p14)	Evenings spent on administration
Contact log	Every call, letter and visit in the timeline automatically	The resident retelling their story
Help and escalate	Safeguarding, legal and complex-case routes in one click	Signals lost in email chains

Adoption discipline: measure desk time saved and error rates, but also ask officers monthly what the tools got wrong. The desk that officers work around is worse than no desk - it produces a shadow process assurance cannot see.



Behind the desk: queue, ageing and accuracy visible to managers in time to act, not to explain.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Co-design with caseworkers is not consultation theatre; their veto on desk changes is real.

SERVICE LENS

If training takes longer than the time the tool saves in its first week, the tool is not ready.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Protect thinking time in the roster. A desk optimised to remove every pause produces fast, shallow decisions.

ACCOUNTABILITY

Records, transparency and the public register

Casework AI touches rights and incomes, so its governance is public, not procedural. Northbridge maintains a public register entry for every casework AI use, written for residents, and keeps records to the standard an appeal, an audit or an inquiry will one day demand.

Register field	Content
Use and purpose	What the tool does, in which scheme, for whose benefit
Human decision point	Where an officer decides, and their role title
Data used	Categories of data, sources, and what is never used
Accuracy	Latest measured accuracy by document and case class, with dates
Equity review	Date and outcome of the last outcome-pattern review (p24)
Correction route	How a resident challenges a record, a summary or a decision
Supplier and model	Vendor, model version, change notification terms

Records discipline

- **The decision record is complete:** facts relied on, rule version, evidence, summary version, drafts and edits, decision and reasons, all timestamped and retained to the scheme's schedule.
- **Residents can see their record** and correct factual errors; corrections propagate to summaries and flag affected decisions.
- **Model changes are case-relevant events.** A new model version is recorded like a guidance change: effective date, evaluation results, and which live cases it touches.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Write the register for a resident with a refusal letter in their hand. If it does not help them, rewrite it.

SERVICE LENS

Retention is a promise in both directions: keep what accountability needs, delete what it does not, on schedule.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

An inquiry will reconstruct a decision from your records or from your absence of them. Choose.

MEASUREMENT

Right first time, fair by group

Casework metrics must hold three truths at once: the decision was fast, the decision was right, and the decision was fair across the population. Any single one, reported alone, misleads.

Measure	Definition	Watch for
Decision time	Median and 90th percentile, application to decision, by scheme	Averages hiding a long tail of hardship
Right first time	Decisions unchanged at reconsideration and quality audit	Speed bought with error
Evidence burden	Items requested per case; repeats; days residents spend gathering	Cost transferred to applicants
Accuracy of AI components	Extraction and summary accuracy by class, sampled (p12-13)	Blended averages masking weak classes
Equity of outcomes	Grant, refusal, time and overturn rates by group, language, channel	Gaps explained as demand without investigation
Officer edit rate	How often drafts and summaries are materially corrected	Rubber-stamping (too low) or useless drafts (too high)
Appeal causes	Overturns coded by cause (p21)	The same cause topping the table quarter after quarter

Publish decision time **and** right-first-time together, always. Separately, each one invites gaming; together, they describe a service.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Review equity cuts quarterly with authority to pause a use case; a review that cannot stop anything is theatre.

SERVICE LENS

Sample quality by reading cases, not only by dashboard. Numbers tell you where to read.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Small groups disappear in averages; report with care for privacy, but never use privacy as a reason not to look.

ECONOMICS

The case for casework AI, honestly counted

The honest economics are favourable - and narrower than vendor decks suggest. Savings concentrate in handling time, error reduction and avoided failure demand. They do not come from deciding more cases per officer by rushing judgement, and they never come from refusal rates.

Benefit	Mechanism	Count it as
Handling time	Extraction, summaries and drafting remove administration	Officer hours released, measured at the desk (p22)
Error reduction	Checks at intake, evidence matching, rule traces	Fewer corrections, overpayments and appeals - costed end to end
Failure demand avoided	Clear letters, complete gap requests, status updates	Contacts that no longer happen because nothing went wrong
Take-up	Checkers and outreach reach eligible non-claimants	A cost, honestly counted - and the point of the scheme
Backlog clearance	One-off recovery from better preparation	One-off, never baselined as recurring efficiency

Cost discipline

- **Full cost:** licences, integration, rules maintenance, evaluation, sampling, safeguarding review time and training - per decided case, trended.
- **Released time is reinvested deliberately:** complex cases, quality sampling and backlog prevention are named in the plan, or the hours evaporate into volume and nothing improves.
- **Refusal is never a saving.** Any business case that improves when refusals rise is rejected on sight; it has confused the budget with the mission.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Take-up rising is success that costs money. Say so in the budget round before someone calls it an overrun.

SERVICE LENS

Track cost per right decision, not per decision; the adjective is the discipline.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Sunset components whose measured accuracy or time saving no longer clears their running cost.

WORKFORCE

Judgement is the job; administration was the interruption

Casework AI changes the caseworker role toward its skilled core: assessing, deciding, explaining, supporting. That transition succeeds only if staff experience it as their work getting better, with their fingerprints on the design.

The workforce standard

- **Role redesign before rollout.** Job content, caseload weighting, quality expectations and career paths are re-agreed per service before tools arrive - administration time saved becomes judgement time, visibly, in the roster.
- **AI literacy for assessors.** Every officer learns what the tools do, where they err, how confidence and citations work, and how to challenge a summary or a draft - assessed practically, on real case patterns.
- **New skills carry status.** Rules maintenance, summary quality sampling, template ownership and equity review become recognised specialisms with progression, not extra duties.
- **No surveillance drift.** Desk analytics measure services, not keystroke-level monitoring of individuals. The boundary is agreed with staff representatives and audited.
- **Disagreement is a feature.** Officers can override any AI output with a reason, overrides are reviewed for learning, and a pattern of overrides is treated as evidence about the tool first.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Headcount promises made before measurement poison adoption; commit to role quality and let the numbers mature.

SERVICE LENS

The best evaluators of casework AI are experienced caseworkers. Staff the evaluation team accordingly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If experienced officers are leaving, pause and find out why before scaling anything.

FAILURE

When casework AI fails, people feel it in their income

Failure here is not a degraded dashboard; it is rent unpaid, a licence unissued, a family wrongly investigated. Plan for failure at that weight: detect fast, protect the resident first, then fix the system.

Failure	Detection	Response
Extraction errors at scale	Sampling accuracy dips; officer correction spikes	Pause the document class; human processing; find and flag affected cases
Wrong rule version live	Change-control reconciliation; appeal cause spike	Revert; identify decisions in the window; proactively review and correct
Summary omissions mislead decisions	Assurance sampling against full records	Withdraw the summariser for that case type; review decisions taken on it
Bias in allocation or outcomes	Quarterly equity review (p24); complaint patterns	Pause the component; investigate as a defect; publish the finding
Supplier outage or model change	Service monitoring; version notifications	Fall back to manual processing with protected clocks; no resident penalty for state downtime
Data incident	Security monitoring and reporting	Contain, notify as law requires, list affected cases, support residents first

The correction promise

Where a system failure affected decisions, the service finds the affected residents itself, corrects the decision, restores losses where law allows, and apologises plainly. Waiting for each person to appeal a failure the service already knows about is a second failure.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Rehearse the pause. A team that has never practised stopping the tool will not stop it under pressure.

SERVICE LENS

Proactive correction costs less than the inquiry. Every time. Budget for it as insurance, proudly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Failure reports go to the same public register as successes, on the same cadence.

SUPPLIERS

Buy components, keep the judgement in-house

Vendors can supply extraction engines, summarisation models and workflow platforms. They cannot supply your statute knowledge, your discretion framework or your accountability - and contracts must make that boundary enforceable.

Contract term	Requirement
Accuracy warranties	Tested on your documents and case classes, with remedies; re-tested at every model change
Change notification	Model, data-use and sub-processor changes notified in advance; no silent updates on live casework
Data terms	Case data never trains shared models; retention and deletion certified; exit export in open formats
Explainability support	Confidence, citations and logs available to your assurance team and, where needed, to appeal processes
Audit rights	Access for your auditors and regulator to evaluation data, incident records and change history
Exit and continuity	Assisted exit, record export tested annually, and manual fallback that the contract keeps viable

- **Evaluate on your hardest cases:** poor scans, handwriting, mixed language, multi-agency chronologies - with accuracy reported by class, not blended.
- **Rules stay yours.** The rules engine and its legal sources are a public asset; no supplier lock-in on the logic that decides rights.
- **Reference the register:** the supplier named publicly (page 23) performs differently from the supplier who is not.

EXECUTIVE LENS

A vendor who resists accuracy testing on your data has told you their accuracy on your data.

SERVICE LENS

Total the exit cost before signing; a cheap pilot with an expensive exit is an expensive system.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Keep enough in-house skill to be an intelligent customer; outsourced understanding cannot be re-tendered.

GATES AND ROADMAP

B0-B5: no casework use scales without evidence

Gate	Question	Evidence required
B0 Mandate	Is this use lawful, wanted and owned?	Named scheme owner; legal basis noted; stop list signed (p7)
B1 Design	Does it help officers decide rightly?	Principles test (p8); caseworker co-design record; resident testing
B2 Readiness	Are rules, data and records sound?	Rules engine traced to law (p10); evidence standards set (p11); register entry drafted
B3 Proof	Does it work on real cases, fairly?	Accuracy by class; equity review; shadow running against human decisions
B4 Controlled live	Does it hold under real load and scrutiny?	Limited cohort; sampling live; appeal causes watched weekly
B5 Scale	Has it earned wider use?	Two quarters of right-first-time and equity data; failure drill passed; workforce ready

The 24-month roadmap (Northbridge, illustrative)

- **Months 0-6:** case audit, rules inventory, evidence standards; extraction and completeness checks in shadow mode for two schemes.
- **Months 7-12:** case summaries and drafting live for benefits intake; eligibility checkers relaunched in plain language; register entries published.
- **Months 13-18:** licensing routes proportioned; pre-filled renewals; allocation support with quarterly equity review.
- **Months 19-24:** change-signal reviews; appeals cause loop fully driving fixes; scale decisions at B5 per scheme, not per platform.

Shadow before live, **scheme by scheme**: a tool proven on housing benefit has earned nothing on disability assessment until it proves itself there.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Hold the gates when the backlog argues. A wrong-decision scandal costs more backlog than any pause.

SERVICE LENS

Gate evidence is published internally in full; assurance by summary is how failures get scheduled.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Skipping B3 shadow running is the single best predictor of a public failure.

TEMPLATES

Templates 1-4: copy, complete, file with the case or the gate record

Template 1 - Use Case Mandate (B0)

Scheme / service: ___ | Owner (name, role): ___ | Legal basis: ___ | Decision the officer keeps: ___ | Stop-list check (p7) signed: ___ | Register entry due: ___

Template 2 - Evidence Standard

Scheme: ___ | Item: ___ | Why the law needs it: ___ | Held-data source checked first: ___ | Formats accepted: ___ | Alternatives of equal standing: ___ | Deadline and why it is realistic: ___

Template 3 - Rule Trace

Case type: ___ | Rule: ___ | Legal source (section): ___ | Guidance version: ___ | Facts engaged: ___ | Discretion point (if any): ___ | Changed on / by: ___

Template 4 - Summary Quality Sample

Week: ___ | Cases sampled: ___ | Facts checked against record: ___ | Omissions found: ___ | Misstatements found: ___ | Action per failure: ___ | Reviewer: ___

Templates set the floor, not the ceiling: a completed template that nobody reads at a gate is stationery. Each template names its gate; the gate reviewer signs against the evidence, not the intention.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Templates belong to scheme owners; version them like guidance, with dates and change notes.

SERVICE LENS

If a field is always blank, the template is asking the wrong question - fix the template.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

File completed templates where an auditor will look first, not where the project keeps its slides.

Templates 5-8 and the assurance checklist

Template 5 - Decision Letter Check

Case: ___ | Outcome matches signed assessment: Y/N | Reasons true and complete: Y/N | Evidence listed: Y/N | Appeal route and deadline correct: Y/N | Plain language read-aloud test: Y/N | Signed by: ___

Template 6 - Allocation Review

Period: ___ | Routing factors used: ___ | Overrides and reasons: ___ | Outcome patterns by group reviewed: Y/N | Disparity found / action: ___ | Reviewer: ___

Template 7 - Appeal Cause Log

Case: ___ | Original decision and officer: ___ | Reconsideration officer (fresh): ___ | Outcome: upheld / overturned | Cause code: evidence missed / rule misapplied / discretion / unclear letter / new facts | Fix owner and date: ___

Template 8 - Failure and Correction Record

Failure: ___ | Detected how / when: ___ | Component paused: Y/N | Cases in window: ___ | Residents contacted proactively: ___ | Decisions corrected: ___ | Register updated: Y/N | Exec sign-off: ___

Assurance checklist

- Stop list signed, taught and breach-logged (p7)
- Rules traced to legal sources, version history complete (p10)
- Accuracy sampled by document and case class (p12-13)
- Equity of outcomes reviewed this quarter (p24)
- Safeguarding signals reviewed same-day, access logged (p19)
- Appeal causes coded and driving fixes (p21)
- Register entries current, including failures (p23, 27)

EXECUTIVE LENS

The checklist is the audit trail's table of contents; keep the evidence behind every line.

SERVICE LENS

Assurance samples cases, not presentations. Insist on the underlying records.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A checklist that always passes is measuring the checklist.

GOLDEN RULES

20 Golden Rules for benefits, licensing and casework

1. AI prepares; officers decide - and sign.
2. Right first time beats fast, every time.
3. Ask once: never re-request what the state already holds.
4. Explain eligibility before assessing it.
5. Rules as code, law as source - every rule traced to its section.
6. If the summary cannot cite it, the summary cannot say it.
7. Draft after the decision, never before it.
8. One complete gap letter, in plain language, with a realistic deadline.
9. The presumption of honesty governs design; verification is proportionate and explained.
10. Suspicion is not evidence, and a data match is not an accusation.
11. Safeguarding: flag fast to a human, conclude never by machine.
12. Vulnerability changes the route - more support, a named worker - never the rights.
13. Allocation routes on need and skill, never on predicted worthiness.
14. Publish decision time and right-first-time together, or publish neither.
15. Appeals are data; code the causes and fix them in order.
16. Refusal is never a saving in a business case.
17. Take-up rising is success, even when it costs money.
18. When the system fails, find the residents, correct the decisions, apologise first.
19. The original document outranks its extraction in any dispute.
20. The record must let a stranger reconstruct the decision - because one day, one will.

Next: **Volume 4 - Permitting, Planning and Land Use**: completeness, consultation and inspections, where casework meets the built environment.

Northbridge City and County is a fictional composite. All figures marked illustrative are examples for adaptation, not benchmarks. Adapt thresholds to your own statute, budget and risk appetite.